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Cindy Sherman's *Untitled Film Stills*: Estrangement, Performance, and the Theatrical

Construction of Femininity

I. Introduction

Cindy Sherman's *Untitled Film Stills* (1977–1980) remains one of the most influential photographic series in contemporary art because of its openness to multiple and often conflicting interpretations across disciplines. Consisting of sixty-nine black-and-white photographs in which Sherman performs fictional female characters inspired by Hollywood cinema, film noir, B-movies, and European art-house films, the series has generated extensive scholarship within feminist theory, postmodernism, photography studies, visual culture, and performance studies. Critics have alternately interpreted the work as a critique of the male gaze, a parody of cinematic femininity, a postmodern exploration of simulacra, and a meditation on spectatorship and identity construction.

While scholars have examined representation, spectatorship, and performance separately, fewer studies have fully explored how Sherman's images function through theatrical interruption and performative artificiality in ways that destabilize cinematic spectatorship itself. Rather than simply reproducing or critiquing stereotypes, Sherman constructs fictional cinematic scenes that feel culturally familiar because they draw upon collectively shared visual conventions from

Hollywood cinema and mass media. Yet her performances simultaneously disrupt this familiarity through emotional detachment, exaggerated pose, narrative suspension, and theatrical stylization.

This paper asks: How can Sherman's *Untitled Film Stills* be understood through the intersection of art history and theatre/performance studies, particularly through Bertolt Brecht's theory of the *Verfremdungseffekt*, to interrupt cinematic spectatorship and expose femininity as a culturally rehearsed visual performance?

Drawing from art history and theatre/performance studies, this paper argues that Sherman transforms photographic spectatorship into a Brechtian theatrical encounter in which cinematic femininity becomes recognizable precisely through its estrangement. Using Bertolt Brecht's theory of *Verfremdungseffekt* (estrangement effect), Sherman's photographs interrupt cinematic realism through performative artificiality, suspended narrative, and visual repetition.¹ Rather than presenting femininity as an authentic identity, the images expose it as a culturally rehearsed performance constructed through media imagery, spectatorship, and collective visual memory. Sherman's photographs therefore operate less as cinematic narratives than as interrupted theatrical scenes that reveal how femininity is staged and culturally learned through visual media.

II. Historical Context

Sherman began producing *Untitled Film Stills* shortly after moving to New York City in 1977. Emerging within the artistic environment later associated with the Pictures Generation, she worked during a period in which artists increasingly questioned originality, authorship, representation, and

¹ Bertolt Brecht, *Brecht on Theatre: The Development of an Aesthetic*, ed. and trans. John Willett (New York: Hill and Wang, 1964), 91–99; Douglas Robinson, *Estrangement and the Somatics of Literature: Tolstoy, Shklovsky, Brecht* (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 2008), 195–288.

the pervasive influence of mass media imagery. Simultaneously, feminist film theory and postmodern critiques of representation were becoming increasingly influential within both art criticism and academic discourse.

The series consists of carefully staged black-and-white photographs in which Sherman appears as fictional female characters: secretaries, actresses, housewives, ingénues, and women isolated within urban environments or moments of cinematic suspense. Although the photographs evoke recognizable film genres and cinematic archetypes, Sherman repeatedly insisted that the images were not based on specific films or directors. Instead, they operate through collective cinematic memory and shared visual conventions associated with mid-century Hollywood and European cinema. Sherman played multiple roles throughout the production process such as director, model, makeup artist, and performer. The photographs are not spontaneous self-portraits, but highly constructed performances assembled through wigs, costumes, props, gesture, lighting, and theatrical staging. By repeatedly transforming herself into multiple personas, Sherman foregrounds the instability and performativity of identity itself.

The series also emerged during a significant moment in feminist art practice. During the 1970s, feminist artists increasingly challenged representations of women within cinema, advertising, and art history, while feminist film theorists such as Laura Mulvey argued that classical cinema positioned women as objects of a controlling male gaze.² Sherman's photographs entered directly into these debates by simultaneously reproducing and destabilizing cinematic femininity. This ambiguity remains central to the enduring complexity of the series.

² Laura Mulvey, "Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema," *Screen* 16, no. 3 (1975): 6–18.

III. Literature Review

The historiography of Sherman's *Untitled Film Stills* demonstrates a gradual shift from feminist critiques of representation toward broader discussions of spectatorship, performance, theatricality, and intermediality. Early scholarship on Cindy Sherman primarily focused on feminist film theory and postmodernism, interpreting the photographs through questions of the male gaze, cinematic femininity, and the instability of identity and representation.

Among feminist interpretations, Jui-Ch'i Liu offers one of the most significant revisions of earlier scholarship. In "Female Spectatorship and the Masquerade," Liu argues that previous feminist readings often privileged a masculine spectator while overlooking the complexity of female spectatorship. Rather than presenting viewers with a stable critical position, Sherman's photographs generate unstable and shifting forms of identification in which spectators simultaneously recognize, critique, and distance themselves from cinematic stereotypes. Liu therefore moves beyond the question of whether Sherman critiques or reproduces stereotypes, emphasizing instead the instability of spectatorship itself.³

Intermedial and performance-based scholarship shift attention toward staging, mediation, and performative circulation across media. Callens argues that Sherman's images operate across photography, theatre, dance, and performance through repetition, disguise, gesture, and staging. His analysis demonstrates how Sherman's personas circulate performatively across media rather than functioning as fixed representations.⁴ Similarly, Joel Anderson and Wiebke Leister develop

³ Jui-Ch'i Liu, "Female Spectatorship and the Masquerade: Cindy Sherman's *Untitled Film Stills*," *History of Photography* 34, no. 1 (2010): 79–89.

⁴ Johan Callens, "Instance: Anne-Marie Boisvert, *Identité dénudée...*" in *Mapping Intermediality in Performance*, edited by Sarah Bay-Cheng, Chiel Kattenbelt, Andy Lavender, and Robin Nelson. (Amsterdam: Amsterdam University Press, 2010), 210-216.

a performance-centered interpretation in “The Theatre of Photography: Dialogues” by examining how photography and theatre intersect through staging, mediation, and performative address. Rather than understanding photography as static representation, they argue that photographs can function as theatrical encounters that actively structure spectatorship.⁵

Rosalind Krauss further interprets Cindy Sherman’s *Untitled Film Stills* as postmodern constructions of identity in which femininity is produced through cinematic, photographic, and cultural images rather than expressing an authentic self. Drawing on Roland Barthes’s theory of myth and simulacra, Krauss argues that Sherman creates “copies without originals”: photographs that feel familiar because they imitate shared cinematic stereotypes and collective visual memory, even though no actual film exists behind them. For Krauss, Sherman exposes femininity as a performative and mediated construction assembled through pose, costume, lighting, framing, and visual codes rather than a natural or stable identity.⁶

Building upon these feminist, intermedial, and postmodern interpretations, this paper argues that Sherman’s *Untitled Film Stills* can be further understood through the framework of theatrical estrangement. Using Bertolt Brecht’s theory of *Verfremdungseffekt*, this paper argues that Sherman’s photographs function not only as representations of femininity, but as estranged performances that expose gender identity as a rehearsed and ideological construction.

IV. Theatrical Estrangement and the Performance of Femininity

⁵ Joel Anderson and Wiebke Leister, “The Theatre of Photography: Dialogues,” *Photography and Culture* 11, no. 2 (2018): 121–138.

⁶ Rosalind Krauss, *Cindy Sherman 1975–1993* (New York: Rizzoli, 1993), 10–74.

Bertolt Brecht's theory of the *Verfremdungseffekt*, commonly translated as the "estrangement effect," sought to interrupt passive emotional immersion by making familiar social behaviors appear strange and constructed rather than natural. Through visible artifice, exaggerated gesture, and narrative interruption, Brecht encouraged audiences to critically examine the ideological structures shaping social behavior. Rather than disappearing into emotional realism, spectators were meant to remain aware of performance as performance.

Sherman's *Untitled Film Stills* operates similarly through theatrical artificiality and interrupted cinematic spectatorship. Photography intensifies this estrangement because the still image freezes gesture and suspends narrative progression. Unlike cinema, which unfolds through continuous movement and narrative resolution, Sherman's photographs isolate singular performative moments that remain psychologically unresolved. The frozen image prevents complete immersion into cinematic illusion and instead directs attention toward pose, gesture, costume, and theatrical

construction.



Cindy Sherman – *Untitled Film Still #21*, 1978

In *Untitled Film Still #21*, Sherman stages herself within an urban environment that resembles the visual atmosphere of film noir or postwar Hollywood melodrama. Sherman turns her body away from the camera while glancing upward off frame with an expression of uncertainty or apprehension. The image appears suspended between movement and stillness, as if the figure has suddenly noticed something outside the frame. Sherman's body functions less as an expression of authentic selfhood than as a performance of recognizable cultural signs. Her tailored jacket, white collar, hat, and carefully styled hair evoke familiar representations of femininity repeatedly

circulated through mid-century cinema. The viewer immediately recognizes the visual language of the vulnerable urban heroine because cinema has trained audiences to recognize these emotional and bodily codes collectively. Sherman therefore reveals femininity not as innate identity but as a learned performance composed of costume, gesture, posture, and expression.

This process closely parallels Brecht's concept of *Gestus*.⁷ For Brecht, bodily gesture is never neutral; posture, tone, movement, and expression all communicate social ideology. Sherman's backward glance, tense posture, and cinematic styling operate as socially coded gestures that expose how femininity itself is constructed through repeated visual performance. Sherman does not invent these feminine codes but re-performs them in ways that estrange their apparent naturalness. The photograph also parallels Brecht's rejection of theatrical illusion. Brecht opposed forms of theater that encouraged complete emotional immersion and passive spectatorship. Instead, he sought to interrupt illusion so audiences would remain critically aware of performance as performance. Sherman similarly disrupts cinematic realism by withholding narrative clarity. The viewer cannot determine what has happened, what the woman sees, or whether she is genuinely fearful, self-aware, or simply acting. The image resembles not a complete film narrative but an interrupted rehearsal or suspended theatrical scene. Because the narrative remains unresolved, the viewer becomes conscious not of character psychology but of femininity as a performed cultural script.

⁷ Bertolt Brecht, *Brecht on Theatre*, 28.



Cindy Sherman – *Untitled Film Still #34*, 1979.

Sherman intensifies this performative instability in *Untitled Film Still #34*. In this image, Sherman performs a glamorous domestic femininity through pose, costume, makeup, and interior staging. Her body language appears tense and self-conscious: one hand touches her neck while the other loosely holds an object, creating the sense of hesitation or emotional uncertainty.

Like *Untitled Film Still #21*, the pose feels deliberately staged rather than psychologically spontaneous. Sherman appears to be acting out a cinematic role instead of expressing an authentic emotional state. The domestic environment further emphasizes theatrical construction. Candles, framed photographs, mirrors, and furniture transform the interior into a carefully arranged set resembling a film stage more than a lived domestic space. Most importantly, the mirror behind Sherman doubles the figure, reinforcing themes of repetition, self-performance, and instability. Rather than presenting a unified identity, the image fractures femininity into multiple surfaces and reflections.

This doubling strongly recalls Brecht's separation between actor and character. In Brechtian theater, actors were not supposed to disappear completely into illusionistic realism. Instead, performers maintained a critical distance from the characters they portrayed, allowing audiences to remain aware of theatrical construction. Sherman performs a similar operation through photography. She never fully becomes the persona she stages. Instead, she "quotes" femininity by replaying recognizable cinematic stereotypes while simultaneously exposing their artificiality. Sherman's photographs therefore function through contradiction. The images appear emotionally familiar yet strangely artificial; cinematic yet theatrical; psychologically expressive yet emotionally inaccessible. This contradiction produces a Brechtian estrangement effect. The viewer simultaneously identifies with the cinematic image and becomes distanced from it. Femininity appears recognizable precisely because it has been culturally rehearsed through mass media, yet Sherman's exaggerated staging and unresolved narratives expose those feminine identities as unstable performances rather than natural truths.

This relationship between recognition and estrangement can also be understood through Raymond Williams's concept of "structures of feeling."⁸ Williams argues that societies collectively produce emotional and behavioral systems that shape how people experience reality. Audiences learn socially shared codes for fear, desire, vulnerability, glamour, and romance through repeated cultural exposure. Sherman's photographs rely upon these shared emotional structures. Viewers immediately recognize the cinematic woman because popular culture has already trained audiences to read femininity through specific gestures, poses, and visual conventions.

However, Sherman interrupts those structures through theatrical estrangement. By exaggerating pose, suspending narrative resolution, and foregrounding artificial performance, Sherman exposes femininity as a rehearsed cultural construction rather than an authentic inner identity. Her repeated self-performance across *Untitled Film Stills* series further destabilizes stable identity because the same body continuously transforms into different socially recognizable personas. Sherman's body becomes a mutable performative site through which cultural femininity is repeatedly constructed, rehearsed, and disrupted.

Through this interdisciplinary framework combining art history and theatrical performance theory, Sherman's *Untitled Film Stills* can be understood not simply as feminist critiques of representation but as Brechtian performances of estrangement. Sherman transforms cinematic femininity into a visible *Gestus*: a socially conditioned performance composed of bodily gestures, costume, pose, and emotional codes. By interrupting narrative illusion and foregrounding theatrical artificiality, Sherman exposes identity itself as a rehearsed and mediated construction.

⁸ Raymond Williams, *Marxism and Literature* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1977), 128–135.

Her photographs therefore do not merely represent women; they reveal the social and theatrical mechanisms through which femininity is continuously produced and recognized within modern visual culture.

V. Conclusion

Cindy Sherman's *Untitled Film Stills* can be understood not as representations of female stereotypes, but as theatricalized performances that expose the instability and constructed nature of cinematic femininity itself. Through costume, gesture, pose, staging, and narrative suspension, Sherman transforms familiar cinematic archetypes into performative images that oscillate between recognition and estrangement. The photographs appear culturally familiar because they draw upon shared visual conventions from cinema and mass media, yet Sherman simultaneously disrupts that familiarity through theatrical artificiality, emotional ambiguity, and interrupted narrative structure. Sherman does not attempt to escape stereotypes from outside representation. Instead, she inhabits and repeats them performatively, exposing their instability from within the act of performance itself. Her body becomes a mutable performative site through which femininity is continuously rehearsed, circulated, and reconstructed across media culture. In this sense, *Untitled Film Stills* reveals identity not as an authentic or stable essence, but as an ongoing theatrical process shaped through spectatorship, repetition, and collective visual memory.

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